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THE INDIAN PLATE



‘View of Cape Comorin, the Kumla Kumari Pagoda, and islands – from a point 1.25 miles N.E. of the Cape.’ Detail of a pen-and-ink and wash drawing of Cape Comorin by Robert Bruce Foote in 1860.

I can only begin at the end, by which I mean at the very tip of India, where the mainland ends and the waters begin – waters that until recent times were known throughout India as the *kala pani*, which can be translated either as ‘black water’ or ‘waters of death’. To those Hindus who took their religion very seriously, as most did and many still do, those waters were taboo. To sail upon them or even to swim in them was to be fatally polluted. So the ocean effectively marked the limits of Hinduism, which may help to explain why India was never a seafaring nation or, indeed, why